

Rocky Mountain Spotted Fever — What you need to know

A serious tick-borne infection that needs early treatment

Rocky Mountain Spotted Fever (RMSF) is a serious infection spread by ticks. In Arizona, the tick that carries it is the brown dog tick, which can live in and around homes where dogs are kept outdoors. RMSF can become life-threatening within a week of symptoms starting, so **early treatment is critical**.

Symptoms

- High fever (often above 102°F)
- Severe headache
- Muscle pain
- Vomiting and stomach pain
- A rash that often starts on wrists, ankles, palms, and soles, then spreads
- Confusion in severe cases

What you should do

1. Take **doxycycline** exactly as prescribed. Even children should be treated with doxycycline for RMSF — it is the only antibiotic that is reliably effective and the benefits far outweigh the risk of tooth staining at the doses used.
2. Do not wait for blood test results to start treatment. Your doctor will start treatment based on symptoms because RMSF can be fatal if treated late.
3. Watch all household members closely for fever or rash for the next 14 days.
4. Treat all dogs in the household with a tick preventive recommended by your veterinarian. Dogs are the source of the ticks that bite people.
5. Inspect your home and yard for ticks; remove any tick-attractive habitat (piles of debris, dog houses with cracks).

If your dog was diagnosed first

RMSF is **not contagious between people, or directly between pets and people**. But the same ticks that bit your dog can bite the humans in the household. If your dog was diagnosed with RMSF (or any tick-borne disease), every human in the home should be checked for tick attachment, and every animal in the home should be treated with a vet-recommended tick preventive. The household needs to be treated as a unit.

Recovery

If treatment is started within 5 days of symptoms beginning, most people recover fully. Untreated, RMSF has a death rate of about 30%. This is why your doctor will treat you immediately based on symptoms even before lab confirmation.

Call your doctor or go to the emergency room if you have:

- Fever after a known tick bite — at any time within the last 30 days
- Confusion, severe headache, or stiff neck
- A spreading rash, especially with fever
- Severe vomiting that prevents you from keeping medication down

More information

- Arizona Department of Health Services: 602-364-4562
- CDC RMSF page: cdc.gov/rmsf
- Tick-borne disease prevention: cdc.gov/ticks

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